Measuring

We won't be covering the modern vision systems recently available for hollowing here but will in the future. A current lower-tech method is simply the use of a laser beam to indicate the wall thickness. Mounted above your cutting bar, you adjust the position of the laser with respect to the cutting edge so you'll know when that thickness has been obtained. The usual method is to set the laser position away from the cutter edge by the dimension of the wall thickness desired. While cutting, the laser beam shows on the edge of the turning. When the beam falls off the edge, you've achieved that dimension of wall thickness. There are some tricks to setting the dimension based on the area of cutting and the type of cutter being used but those are easily learned at the lathe. An even lower-tech option is the tried and true callipers method. Of course you'll need to turn off the lathe to measure but you can use the larger callipers for measuring down into your form to indicate wall thickness. These callipers come in many sizes and shapes and you can even use a bent coat hanger to check thickness.

Wall thickness can be measured with any of the standard measuring tools that will reach

My favourite is the simple coat hanger or welding rod closed to a gap and then compared as slid inside

Your shopper's checklist

Are you buying for now, the future or both? The mechanics are your choice but the bar size depends on how big and how deep you intend to go. The original style, the scissors style or the two bar weldments will all do the same thing for you when sized properly. You choose your style and the size to cover your needs. Will you need or want a centre steady? They usually are sized based on the swing of the lathe and don't easily adapt as the hollowing rigs might. Is your current banjo and toolrest heavy duty enough for your needs or will you be in the market for a specific toolrest for hollowing? These are incredibly sturdy and will serve you well. They also have specific designs to help prevent falling off the edge. Your cutting choices are your own but the most economical to begin with will be the machinist's tool bits and scrapers. Very easy to grind and very modestly priced. Later on you can consider the carbide cutters if you wish. Pricier and a bit trickier so get your basics under your belt before you launch into these. If you are new to the market, don't be afraid to consider used equipment. Properly cared for, there is little to go wrong or wear out on hollowing equipment so bargain pricing may be had when buying second-hand. What about home built? I have used and own some home-built versions of hollowing systems. If they are built properly, they can be as functional as the commercially available units. Do take care that any home-built units are of the proper materials and have had quality welding done on them. Also be certain that the hardware is of the proper strengths. Commercial units will have grade 3 or grade 5 hardware to be certain it is up to the loading it will see. Be certain that home-built units have the appropriate hardware used.

Conclusions

Not every woodturner will have a need for a hollowing system but I must admit they are a lot of fun when you do. If you make hollow forms of any kind, you'll find the advantages of a hollowing system priceless. Once set up, the ease of 'steering' the cut with only fingertip efforts will get you spoiled. None of the systems I am familiar with is inexpensive but they are a once in a lifetime buy if you select properly. Before you take the plunge, seek out a fellow turner who has a hollowing system they are willing to let you try out. With their assistance, spend a bit of time creating something from a fresh cut end grain mounted blank and I'm betting you'll be in the market for a hollowing system soon. ●

A hollowing system makes your hollowing tasks simpler and enables you to do others

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